

REVOLTS AND THE RAILWAYS

Apart from commerce and transport, one of the primary objectives of introducing railways in India was easy troop movements. The rail infrastructure, however, was so vast that it was not easy to protect it from vandalism during the uprisings and rebellions that plagued the British in its colony.



▲ **An illustration of** Richard Vicars Boyle's house at Arrah being defended from mutineers by British sepoy soldiers.

On 11 May 1857, a group of soldiers, after killing European officers in Meerut the day before, marched to the Red Fort in Delhi. They proclaimed Bahadur Shah Zafar, the “nominal” last Mughal Emperor, to be the Emperor of India, and set off what has retrospectively been called either the First War of Indian Independence or the Sepoy Mutiny, depending on the narrator. The movement spread quickly, engulfing most of northern and some parts of central and western India. The south remained more or less unaffected. Railway construction came to a screeching halt as it became a popular target for the rebels. While